

Find undefended pieces

Foundations

THE IDEA

An undefended piece has no friendly protector on its square. It may be perfectly safe now but become a tactical target when checks or forks arrive. Several loose pieces make double attacks especially dangerous.

WORKED EXAMPLE

If a queen and rook are both loose, a knight fork can threaten both even when neither was attacked a move earlier. Moving one piece to a defended square may remove the combination without addressing the knight directly.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

Does a defended piece automatically resist a tactic?

ANSWER AND REASONING

No. Its defender may be pinned, overloaded, removable, or unable to recapture because of mate. Defense must be tested through legal moves, not just counted as a line on the board.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Loose pieces deserve attention before an attack starts.